Curious About Medicaid for Mom Someday? Three Things to Get Onto Paper First

Three first moves, in order, and what can wait for a professional.

A friend mentioned Medicaid and her father's long-term care, and it got you wondering about Mom. She's managing fine, and nobody is applying for anything. You'd just like to know where a family begins.

Begin with paper. Three things, in this order, an evening at a time.

1

Write down how Mom is doing today

Put today's date at the top of a page. Write the state she lives in, whether she's married, and what a usual week looks like: what she does on her own, and anything she gets a hand with, even small things like the heavy shopping or the checkbook. The Administration for Community Living explains that Medicaid has general and financial requirements, and then additional functional requirements for long-term care services, so how she's managing is part of the picture. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST It's the part you already know, and it takes no paperwork. The other two pages are read alongside it.

2

List what she has, as far as you know it

On a second page, list each source of income and each account, policy and piece of property by name: her Social Security, the pension, the checking account, the house. Beside each one, write whose name is on it and whether you've seen it on paper or only remember it. Leave the totals off. The Administration for Community Living notes that a state counts some assets and excludes others, and that sorting them out can be fairly complex. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A list with its blanks showing is something a professional can work from. Which items a state counts is theirs to say, so a total of your own wouldn't tell you much.

3

Write down what you've heard, and what you'd ask

On a third page, list what the family believes about Medicaid and where each idea came from: “she has too much,” “Medicare would cover it,” “the house would count.” Turn each one into a question. One you can check today: Medicare.gov says Medicare doesn't pay for long-term care. For most of the others, the answer depends on where Mom lives, because eligibility rules vary from state to state. [2] [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST These beliefs are what the family is going on now. Written as questions, they can be put to someone who knows Mom's state.

What can wait for a professional

- Whether Mom would qualify. Nobody can tell that from a kitchen-table list, and this page doesn't try.
- Sorting what she has into what counts and what doesn't, or adding it up.
- What the rules are in her state. That is the review your Medicaid planner does, with your three pages in hand.
- Tracking down every statement. A name and “not found yet” is enough for now.
- Any decision about her money, her house or her insurance. Legal questions go to an elder law attorney, and financial ones to a licensed financial professional.

One thing to leave as it is

While you write, leave Mom's accounts, her deed and her policies as they are. If the family has talked about a gift, a new name on an account or any other change, add it to the third page as a question, and take it to a professional who knows her state before anything is done. How a change like that is treated depends on the state and the details.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether Mom would qualify for Medicaid, add anything up, or compare anything with a limit. It isn't legal, financial or tax advice. It puts the first three things in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've got three dated pages: how Mom is doing, what she has as far as you know it, and what you'd ask. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation one part at a time and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

That Medicaid looks at care needs as well as finances, and that a state counts some assets and excludes others, follow the Administration for Community Living's long-term care pages. That Medicare doesn't pay for long-term care is Medicare.gov's own statement. The three moves and their order are ours.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid Eligibility
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Long Term Care Coverage
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid